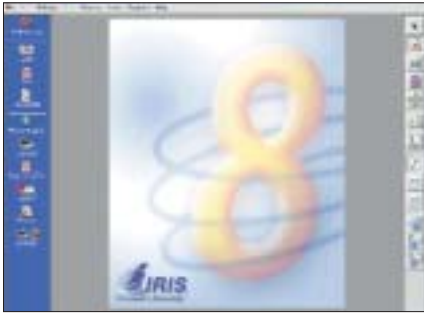




Readiris Pro has a friendly interface

input directly from a scanner, or from an image file. Input can be in a variety of image formats such as bmp, tif, pcx, png and, notably, pdf files too. Readiris supports all the output formats you'd need, from common ones such as Microsoft Word and Excel to html, pdf, Wordstar and WordPerfect. The program automatically recognises the layout and separates the image into text, pictures and tables. It demarcates these by placing coloured boxes around them whose size and type may be manually corrected. This feature is found in almost all the software in our tests.

It fared decently on the easier tests such as the typewritten and fax documents. In the inkjet document test, it did a fairly decent job of recognising the document and also retained most of its formatting. However, when it came to the real test such as the newspaper, magazine and Excel pages, it gave very poor results. Readiris failed to recognise a single character from the magazine page. In the newspaper test, it retained the layout for the main news columns, but the headlines were in disarray.

It does come with a learning capability so that the software learns from the clarification that you provide for a character. Yet, in the inkjet test, it failed to recognise

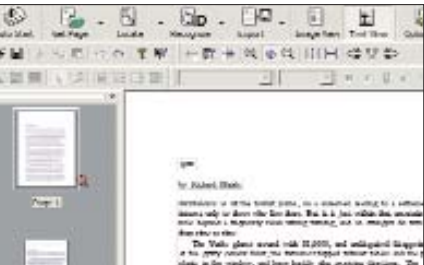
the '®' symbol even after manually entering it twice in the learn mode.

All in all, at \$402 (Rs 18,492) consider Readiris only if you need basic-level OCR with support for different document types, but not if you intend working exclusively with newspaper clippings.

- + Support for various document formats
- Not suitable for complex documents; expensive

TypeReader 6.0
Can do without

TypeReader was pretty accurate in the simpler tests involving inkjet-type documents. However, like Readiris, while recognising complex documents such as newspaper clips and Excel sheets, it yield-



TypeReader is suitable for recognising simple documents

ed very poor, practically unusable results. The software also lacks the auto-orientation feature. This might mean that you won't be able to do batch processing, if you're your documents are oriented sideways.

TypeReader allows OCRing several documents sequentially in a single step. You can start the application and click the Auto Start button to start up the wizard, select all the files that need to be recog-

nised and click Get. All unrecognised characters are replaced by the '~' symbol, which can be changed manually. All suspect characters are highlighted.

TypeReader lacks support for processing PDF files. Recognised data can be exported as Word or Excel files, or to an e-mail client. A preview of all the imported images is shown in a pane. However, you cannot group documents, and store output files accordingly in different folders.

TypeReader allows you to create and save templates. You can supply the template in which the location of the text, picture and table are specified. Any document in the same format can be recognised using that saved template. This comes handy while processing invoices and similar documents that have a standard layout.

The final verdict—consider TypeReader only if you have a lot of simple documents that need to be OCRed. A price tag of \$249 (Rs 11,454) isn't justified.

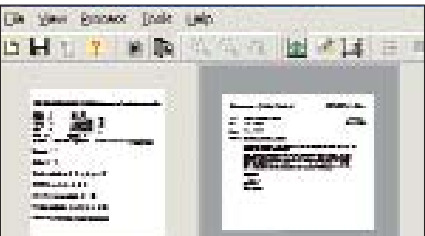
- + Support for creating document templates
- Mediocre results

SimpleOCR

For simple requirements

The only edge that SimpleOCR had over the other tested software is that it's free. The least accurate of the pack, it's suitable for those who rarely use OCR, and are ready to correct errors patiently. It failed to retain even the most basic formatting such as Bold and Italics. It was able to recognise text in the Excel test, but the output was totally unformatted. The results of the newspaper and magazine page tests are not even worthy of a comment.

Input can be from a scanner or from an image file. It supports only the .tif, .jpg and .bmp file formats. You can open multiple documents and save them as batch files that can be later opened to import all the images. It doesn't have a wizard to simplify extraction of text from images, but the self-explanatory buttons are sufficient. Import the images and click on 'Convert to



SimpleOCR was the least accurate of the pack

Leave it to ABBYY

- STEP 1** The Welcome screen displays Tutorial and other such buttons. If you'd like help at this stage, click on one of the buttons or else, click 'Close'.
- STEP 2** You now see the 'Scan and Read', 'Scan', 'Read', buttons. Place your document, after brushing off any dust from it, in your scanner, and click 'Scan'.
- STEP 3** After you've pressed 'Scan', FineReader invokes your scanner's built-in scanning software. The software then asks what you want it to do. Choose 'Scan Now'.

- STEP 4** The scanned image appears in a new pane, and you can now press 'Read' to recognise the scan.
- STEP 5** After recognition, the text appears in the text window for you to edit.
- STEP 6** Finally, choose the Save Wizard from the drop-down menu on the 'Save' button. The wizard asks you what you want to do—save it as a file in the application of your choice, export it to your Web browser, or copy the text to the Windows clipboard, and so on. Make your selection and let the wizard complete the process.